MODULE 11 · DOMAIN 3 - PRODUCT AND MODEL SELECTION

Choosing the Feature

Chat, Projects, research, web search, artifacts, code execution, Skills and connectors: which one each task needs, and why.

DOMAIN 3 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 12% MODULE 11 of 33

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Every feature answers one question: what does this task need **that a plain chat cannot give it**?

Match the need to the feature

IF THE TASK NEEDS...	USE
A quick answer, draft or rewrite	Chat
The same context across many chats or people	A Project
Many sources, cited, and you can wait minutes	Research mode
One current fact from the web	Web search
Something to keep, share, edit or present	An artifact
Exact calculation, charts or real files	Code execution
A repeatable procedure or file-format expertise	A Skill
Live data from Drive, Gmail or Calendar	A connector

ON THE EXAM

Start from the need, not the feature. The simplest feature that meets the need wins.

Chat, or a Project?

A CHAT

One-off and personal

- A single task
- Material pasted for this job
- Nobody else needs it
- Gone when you move on

A PROJECT

Ongoing and shared

- Recurring work
- Instructions and files stored once
- Shared with the team
- Its own memory, separate from other work

THE TIEBREAKER

Same material, many chats, several people: a Project.

Web search, or research mode?

WEB SEARCH

One quick, current fact

- A few searches
- Seconds
- Answer with citations
- Light on your usage

RESEARCH MODE

A cited investigation

- Many searches, each building on the last
- Minutes, sometimes longer
- A report with citations
- Uses your limits faster

THE TIEBREAKER

One fact now: web search. Many sources, a cited picture, time to wait: research.

Code execution: real calculation, real files

- **Claude writes and runs real code** in a private sandbox, so arithmetic is exact rather than estimated in prose.
- **Analyses uploaded files:** spreadsheets, CSV files, tables in PDFs.
- **Creates files:** spreadsheets with formulas and charts, Word documents, slide decks, PDFs.
- **Still sanity-check the result** against what you would expect, before anyone relies on it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Deterministic calculation or a real file: code execution. Sums written in a reply are not calculations.

Totals in a reply, or totals from code?

WHAT HAPPENED

"Total these twelve tabs"

- Totals typed into a chat reply
- Two of them were wrong
- They looked perfectly sensible

WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN

Upload, calculate, check

- Upload the workbook
- Code execution calculates the totals
- Output a summary sheet
- Sanity-check against last month

THE TIEBREAKER

Exact numbers from a file: let code calculate them, then check them.

Skills: packaged expertise, loaded when relevant

- **A Skill packages instructions, scripts and resources** for a task. Claude loads it when it is relevant.
- **Built-in Skills** handle Word, Excel, PowerPoint and PDF files.
- **Custom Skills** capture your own procedures, such as Halden's tender response format.
- **Reusable anywhere**, unlike instructions written into a single Project.
- **Install only from trusted sources.** Module 20 covers the checks.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A procedure repeated across many Projects or chats is a candidate for a Skill.

Connectors: live data from other systems

- **Google Drive** brings in documents. **Gmail** reads mail and creates drafts. **Calendar** reads and changes events.
- **Gmail drafts; you send.** Claude cannot send email on your behalf through it.
- **Each action needs your approval**, and on Team and Enterprise an owner enables connectors first.
- **A directory of others**, such as Microsoft 365, Slack and GitHub, plus custom connectors.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If the data lives in another system and changes, a connector beats a copied file.

Look-alikes to keep apart

IF YOU ARE THINKING...	CHECK WHETHER IT IS REALLY...
Memory, for shared team files	A Project: memory is about you, not a team library
A Project, for one quick task	A chat: no setup needed
Research, for one fact	Web search: faster and lighter
Project instructions, reused everywhere	A Skill: portable across Projects
Uploading a copy of live data	A connector: always current

ON THE EXAM

Most wrong feature answers are a near neighbour of the right one.

The new Claude experience

- **16 Sep 2026:** chat and Cowork merged into one Claude app, rolling out plan by plan.
- **Claude picks the tools.** It searches the web when that helps; there is no web search switch.
- **Longer tasks can run in the cloud**, and agentic work uses more of your limit.
- **Other surfaces:** Claude in Chrome, and Claude inside Excel, PowerPoint and Word.
- **Exam rule:** choose by what the task needs. Buttons move; purposes do not.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The guide names chat, Projects, research mode and Artifacts. Answer in those terms.

> Halden's finance analyst needs regional totals from a twelve-tab month-end workbook for the quarterly report. Last month, totals Claude typed into a chat reply were wrong.
>
> The totals must be exact, and the finance director wants a summary sheet she can check.

Which approach fits best?

A. Upload the workbook, use code execution to calculate the totals and build a summary sheet, then sanity-check it

B. Ask Claude to add the figures more carefully in its reply this time

C. Use research mode to look up how to total the workbook

D. Add the workbook to a Project as knowledge, and ask for the totals

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach fits best?

A Upload the workbook, use code execution to calculate the totals and build a summary sheet, then sanity-check it

Exact calculation, a real file, and a check.

B Ask Claude to add the figures more carefully in its reply this time

Same method that failed. Care does not make prose arithmetic exact.

C Use research mode to look up how to total the workbook

The task is calculation, not finding information.

D Add the workbook to a Project as knowledge, and ask for the totals

Storing the file does not make the arithmetic exact.

THE SIGNAL

Exact totals and a checkable sheet: code execution.

> A Halden bid writer is completing a tender form and needs one fact: the registered address of a prospective client's head office, published on its website.
>
> The form is due in an hour.

Which feature fits best?

A Research mode, for a full cited report on the client

B A new Project for the client, with past correspondence uploaded

C Code execution, to extract the address

D A quick question with web search, then open the cited page to confirm it

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which feature fits best?

A Research mode, for a full cited report on the client

Minutes of work and extra usage for a single fact.

B A new Project for the client, with past correspondence uploaded

Setup for a one-off need, and old letters may be out of date.

C Code execution, to extract the address

Nothing to calculate or build.

D A quick question with web search, then open the cited page to confirm it

One current public fact, found fast, and checked at the source.

THE SIGNAL

One current public fact, needed now: web search, then check the citation.

> Halden's teams describe five different needs to their Claude champion.
>
> She wants to set up Projects only where they will genuinely help.

Which two needs are best met by a Project? Choose two.

A Translating one paragraph of a notice for a site

B The learning team building twenty courses over months to the same course standards and templates

C A one-off cited overview of trends in the facilities market

D Totalling a single spreadsheet of overtime claims

E Customer success using the same tone rules and account notes for its largest client across many staff

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two needs are best met by a Project? Choose two.

A. Translating one paragraph of a notice for a site

One-off and short. A chat.

B. The learning team building twenty courses over months to the same course standards and templates

Recurring work, stable standards, many chats.

C. A one-off cited overview of trends in the facilities market

One-off and cited. Research mode.

D. Totalling a single spreadsheet of overtime claims

Exact calculation. Code execution.

E. Customer success using the same tone rules and account notes for its largest client across many staff

Shared, lasting context for several people.

THE SIGNAL

Recurring work, stable context, several people: those are Projects.

> Every Halden tender response must follow a strict house procedure: numbered answers, a compliance table, and word limits per section.
>
> Bid writers paste the same long instructions into chats across many different client Projects, and some versions have drifted.

Which feature best packages this procedure for reuse?

A. A Skill containing the response procedure and template

B. Memory, so Claude remembers the procedure for each writer

C. Web search, to find the procedure online each time

D. An artifact holding the instructions, shared with the team

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which feature best packages this procedure for reuse?

A A Skill containing the response procedure and template

One maintained procedure, loaded wherever it is relevant, across Projects.

B Memory, so Claude remembers the procedure for each writer

Personal and inexact. Not a controlled, shared procedure.

C Web search, to find the procedure online each time

It is Halden's internal procedure. It is not on the web.

D An artifact holding the instructions, shared with the team

Still copied and pasted, so versions keep drifting.

THE SIGNAL

A repeatable procedure, used across many Projects, with drifting copies: a Skill.

> A Halden account manager wants Claude to find last week's emails from a client about a missed visit, summarise them, and prepare a reply.
>
> Gmail is connected to Halden's Claude workspace.

Which approach fits best?

A Copy and paste each email into a new chat by hand

B Use the Gmail connector to find the emails and create a draft reply, which she reviews and sends

C Use research mode to search for the client's emails

D Have Claude send the reply automatically through the Gmail connector

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach fits best?

A Copy and paste each email into a new chat by hand

Works, but slow and error-prone when a connector exists.

B Use the Gmail connector to find the emails and create a draft reply, which she reviews and sends

Live data, a draft, and a person sends.

C Use research mode to search for the client's emails

Research searches the web, not her mailbox, unless connected.

D Have Claude send the reply automatically through the Gmail connector

The Gmail connector creates drafts. It does not send.

THE SIGNAL

Live email data: the connector. Gmail drafts; a person sends.

> Halden's HR director wants a briefing on how large UK employers are approaching four-day working weeks, drawing on many recent public sources.
>
> Every claim must be cited, and she is happy to wait while it is prepared.

Which feature fits best?

A. A plain chat, asking Claude to answer from what it already knows

B. A quick web search for a single article on the topic

C. Research mode, which runs many searches and cites its sources

D. Code execution, to analyse the sources

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which feature fits best?

A A plain chat, asking Claude to answer from what it already knows

No citations, and knowledge stops at a cutoff.

B A quick web search for a single article on the topic

One source cannot give a picture across many employers.

C Research mode, which runs many searches and cites its sources

Many recent sources, every claim cited, time to wait.

D Code execution, to analyse the sources

Reading and synthesis, not calculation.

THE SIGNAL

Many recent sources, everything cited, time to wait: research mode.

> A Halden supervisor wants to make one paragraph of an internal email to her team sound friendlier.
>
> She will never need to do anything similar with this text again.

Which feature fits best?

A A plain chat

B A new Project for team communications

C Research mode, to find examples of friendly emails

D A custom Skill for friendly writing

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which feature fits best?

A A plain chat

Quick, one-off rewriting. Nothing more is needed.

B A new Project for team communications

Setup for something she will never repeat.

C Research mode, to find examples of friendly emails

Minutes of searching for a one-line rewrite.

D A custom Skill for friendly writing

Building a reusable package for a one-off task.

THE SIGNAL

Nothing the task needs is beyond a plain chat: use the plain chat.

> Halden's board wants the findings of a Claude-drafted operations review as a slide deck. The chair will edit it, then present it from PowerPoint.
>
> The findings are already written and checked.

Which approach fits best?

A. Inline bullet points in the chat, for the chair to paste into slides

B. Research mode, to gather more evidence for the deck

C. Turn on Memory so Claude remembers the findings for next time

D. A slide deck as an artifact or created file, exported to PowerPoint for the chair to edit

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach fits best?

A Inline bullet points in the chat, for the chair to paste into slides

Leaves the chair to build the deck by hand.

B Research mode, to gather more evidence for the deck

The findings are already written and checked.

C Turn on Memory so Claude remembers the findings for next time

Does not produce a deck at all.

D A slide deck as an artifact or created file, exported to PowerPoint for the chair to edit

Something to edit and present, in the format she will use.

THE SIGNAL

Edited, presented, needed in PowerPoint: a deck, as an artifact or a created file.

In five lines

- **Ask what the task needs that a plain chat cannot give.** Nothing? Use the chat.
- **Shared, lasting context:** Project. **One fact:** web search. **Many cited sources:** research.
- **Exact numbers or real files:** code execution. **Keep or present:** artifact.
- **Reusable procedure:** Skill. **Live company data:** connector; Gmail drafts, you send.
- **Buttons move, purposes do not.** Answer by what the feature is for.

COMING UP

Next: choosing the model, Haiku, Sonnet, Opus and above.